Common Ground as Accidental Convergence

Abstract. Theorists of conversation standardly posit a single common ground, variously defined as common belief, common acceptance, common knowledge of acceptance, or shared commitment, and ask it to do two jobs: license presupposition and coordinate the joint conduct of talk. I argue that no single state does both. What may be presupposed in assertion without challenge tracks what is publicly settled; what may be insinuated, left implicit, or designed for a particular audience tracks what participants mutually represent, settled or not. The two come apart in both directions, even within a single conversation, repair differently when they fail, and change independently as a single content moves onto the record. I conclude that common ground is the accidental convergence of two independently operating mechanisms, one of mutual public commitment and one of mutual representation, which usually coincide because they answer to the same inputs.

1. Introduction

When I tell a colleague that my son has started looking at colleges, I take for granted that she knows I have a son. When I later remark that some people seem to vote on proposals they haven't read, I take for granted something else: that she will recognize whom I mean, and that neither of us will say so. Both utterances lean on something shared. The standard view in philosophy of language and pragmatics is that they lean on the same thing, namely the *common ground* of the conversation, and that the difference between them is a difference in how each utterance exploits it.

That standard view comes in several versions. On Stalnaker's (1978, 2002, 2014) influential account, the common ground is what the participants commonly accept for the purposes of the conversation. Yalcin (2024) has argued that p is common ground just in case it is common knowledge that p is accepted. Geurts (2019) proposes that common ground consists of shared commitments, though he has since called mentalist and normative accounts complementary (Geurts 2024). Clark and Brennan (1991) treat common ground as the product of *grounding*, which establishes mutual belief sufficient for current purposes. Camp (2018) distinguishes a conversational *record* of what speakers are officially on the hook for from the common ground. And the scoreboard tradition (Lewis 1979; Thomason 1990; Roberts 2012; Farkas & Bruce 2010) already treats context as having several components. These views disagree about what common ground is. But most share an assumption: one thing, or one structured thing, answers to the name, and a theory of common ground should say what it is. Clark (1996) holds the assumption most explicitly, making common ground the basis of every joint activity, reference and presupposition included. Stalnaker does not ask common ground to coordinate insinuation, but he treats it as the background for pragmatic reasoning generally, and Yalcin's

definition is fitted to that role.

I think that assumption is false. My thesis is that common ground is not a single phenomenon but the accidental convergence of at least two independently operating mechanisms. One tracks *mutual public commitment*, and it licenses what can be presupposed in assertion without challenge. The other tracks *mutual representation*, what the participants represent one another as representing, and it coordinates joint activity, conversation included. Among the things it licenses are insinuation and other off-record ways of conveying content. In ordinary talk the two mechanisms deliver the same verdicts, which is why theorists have been able to treat them as one. But they come apart, and when they do, they come apart systematically.

Much of this is not new, and it is worth saying exactly what is. That presupposition tracks commitment rather than belief is Geurts's point, and that record and common ground can come apart is Camp's. Two recent papers go further. Simons (2025) argues that the information available for interpretation is not the common ground, citing insinuation among her evidence. Bary (2025) argues that common ground cannot "do double duty," splits it into common beliefs, which shape how utterances are formulated, and commitments, which capture what assertion does, and shows that each can exist without the other. I agree with both. What remains to be shown is threefold. First, the relatum opposed to commitment is not belief but mutual representation, and commitment can outrun representation itself, not merely belief, within a single conversation. Second, the division of labor is not Bary's: informative presupposition answers to commitment, not to common belief. Third, the ordinary coincidence of the two has an explanation, in common inputs, which also predicts where they come apart. Along the way I identify an asymmetry in repair, and I conclude that the foundational question "what is common ground?" has no single answer.

Section 2 distinguishes two classes of move. Section 3 establishes the *publicity differential*. Sections 4 through 6 take up insinuation, repair, and a single content's passage onto the record. Section 7 argues for independence, Section 8 weighs the costs of unification, and Section 9 asks whether the disagreement is merely verbal.

2. Two classes of move

Some conversational moves are evaluated by reference to what has been *settled*. Assertion is the paradigm. When I assert that the committee's vote was a mistake, I presuppose that there was a vote, and my assertion is in good order only if I am entitled to treat that presupposition as beyond dispute. Other moves are evaluated by reference to what the participants *have in view*. When I say "the proposal" rather than "the curriculum revision the department circulated in August," I design my utterance for a hearer I take to be tracking what I am. When she says "mm-hm," she signals that she is following, without agreeing to anything. These moves conduct the conversation as a joint activity, and their felicity does not depend on anything's

having been settled.

Call the standing that the first class of moves requires *public standing*. A content has public standing in a conversation when the participants are mutually committed to it, in roughly Brandom's (1994) or Geurts's (2019) sense: each is answerable for it, each may cite it without further warrant, and anyone who goes on to act or speak against it can be held to account. Public standing is a normative status, conferred by acts, paradigmatically assertion and its acceptance, and it persists until retracted or overridden. Call the standing that the second class requires *mutual representation*. A content is mutually represented when each participant represents it and represents the others as representing it, to whatever depth current purposes require (Clark & Brennan 1991), rather than to the infinite depth of Lewis (1969) or Schiffer (1972). I also follow Stalnaker, Clark, and Camp in taking the relevant representations to be dispositional rather than occurrent: a content is represented if the participants can bring it to bear from memory when the conversation calls for it. It is a psychological condition, not a normative one, and it is not belief: we can mutually represent a suspicion I have insinuated, or the plot of a novel, without accepting either. Nor is it Sperber and Wilson's (1995) mutual manifestness, its closest relative. A content is manifest when it is available to be represented; it is mutually represented when it actually is, on both sides. Manifestness is the main input to mutual representation, and Section 7 shows that the two can come apart. Finally, I call each a mechanism in roughly the interventionist sense (Woodward 2003): each can be changed without changing the other, and each has its own conditions of creation, persistence, and repair. The double dissociation of Sections 3 and 7 is evidence of the first, and the causal explanation of Section 7 requires it. I do not claim that the second is a single cognitive module; it may be a family of capacities (tracking salience, designing for an audience, recognizing intentions) that share those conditions. Nor is the mapping from phenomena to mechanisms one-to-one: Section 3 assigns some presuppositions to each.

The first claim of this paper, then, is a claim of correlation. What may be presupposed in assertion without challenge tracks public standing. What conducts conversation as a joint activity, including what may be left implicit or insinuated, tracks mutual representation, whether or not the content has public standing. Single-notion accounts assume that one of these tracks the other closely enough to be ignored. The next section argues that the first correlation holds even where the second kind of standing is fully in place.

3. The publicity differential

Ana and Ben's son brings home a report card, and it sits open on the kitchen counter. Ana reads it while Ben is in the room; Ben reads it while Ana watches. Each sees the failing grade in chemistry, sees the other see it, and sees the other register it. By Clark and Marshall's (1981) standard of physical co-presence, nothing more could be done to make the fact mu-

tually known, short of saying it. By Stalnaker's, it is already presupposed: "If a goat walked into the room, it would normally be presupposed, from that point, that there was a goat in the room" (1978, 323). Neither says it. That evening Ana says:

(1) Since he's failing chemistry, we need to take his phone away on school nights.

Ben replies, "Whoa. Hold on. We haven't even talked about the report card yet."

Now compare a second version of the case, identical except that when the report card arrived Ana said, "He's failing chemistry," and Ben said, "I saw." In this version (1) draws no such reply. Ben may resist the phone policy, but he cannot complain that Ana is treating the grade as settled. Nothing institutional is at stake in either version. The only difference between the versions is whether the fact has been said between them.

Ben's reply is a version of the "Hey, wait a minute" response that von Fintel (2004), following Shanon (1976), identified as a diagnostic of presupposition, but it needs careful handling. Abbott (2008) and Tonhauser, Beaver, Roberts, and Simons (2013) have shown that many triggers do not require their content to be common ground in advance; the content of a "since" clause can be new and simply accommodated. So the question is not whether (1) is semantically defective. It isn't. The question is whether Ben has standing to refuse the accommodation (1) asks for. In the first version he does; in the second he does not. He is not expressing doubt or telling Ana anything she didn't know. Nor is the trouble that the topic cannot be broached: had Ana said, "He's failing chemistry, and I think we need to take his phone away," Ben would have had no complaint of the same kind. What was wrong with (1) was not that it raised the matter but that it treated the matter as already raised.

Call this pattern the *publicity differential*: a hearer's standing to refuse a presupposition as not yet settled tracks whether its content has public standing, not whether it is mutually known. Stalnaker's goat principle predicts otherwise. If manifestness sufficed, the grade would already be presupposed, and Ben's complaint would be as odd as "Hold on, we haven't talked about the goat." The contrast is instructive. Stalnaker's goat is exploited with a demonstrative ("How did that thing get in here?"), and demonstratives belong to what Tonhauser and colleagues call strong-contextual-felicity triggers, which need an antecedent already established in context. Manifestness can supply one, and so such presuppositions are licensed by mutual representation, the second of my mechanisms. The publicity differential concerns the rest: content that can be presupposed informatively and is therefore offered for accommodation, which the hearer may accept or refuse.

A referee might say that Ben's complaint expresses a sequencing or face norm, that significant matters should be raised before they are built on, rather than anything about presupposition. I grant the norm. But consider what it says. It is a norm on what may be built on without challenge, sensitive to whether something has been said and insensitive to whether it is mutually known. That is the explanandum, whatever we call it, and a theory on which

presupposition answers to a single attitudinal state has no way to state it. Nor is the complaint about the turn to punishment, or to practical deliberation: the second version contains the same turn, and Ben may resist it there, but he cannot say the report card has not been discussed. If one prefers to call what he lacks a normative conversational entitlement rather than a presuppositional one, the label changes nothing. It is the first mechanism either way.

The Stalnakerian has a better reply. Common ground is common *acceptance* for the purposes of the conversation, not common *belief*, and Ben has not accepted, for these purposes, that his son is failing chemistry. He has a policy not to treat the proposition as settled here, and the policy is not idle, since it explains his veto. I grant this too. The question is what the policy answers to. Ben's beliefs, his beliefs about Ana's beliefs, and his plans are the same in both versions; only whether the fact has been said differs. And the policy is not up to him in the way policies usually are. In the second version, having said "I saw," Ben cannot coherently insist that the matter is unsettled between them, whatever he might prefer. So the policy that constitutes his acceptance is a policy of treating as settled what has been placed on the record.

This is not circular, since public standing is conferred by acts, not by acceptance. What it does is relocate acceptance: it is the attitude by which each participant registers the public status of a content, the individual-level face of the first mechanism rather than an alternative to it. The Stalnakerian may keep the word. What she cannot keep is the claim that one iterated attitude underwrites both presupposition and the coordination of Section 4, since insinuated content is exactly what no participant has a policy of treating as settled. Yalcin's (2024) refinement, on which p is common ground just in case it is common knowledge that p is accepted, has the same structure. There is common knowledge here in abundance. What is lacking is acceptance, and acceptance is lacking because nothing public has happened.

If the publicity differential holds, then what settles a presupposition beyond challenge cannot be analyzed in terms of what participants represent, however deeply iterated, because the two versions hold all representational states fixed and vary only public standing. Mutual belief is usually present when presupposition succeeds, and Section 7 argues that this is no accident. But it is not what presupposition *answers to*.

4. What mutual representation governs

If public standing licenses presupposition, what does mutual representation do? It coordinates joint activity. Clark (1996) argued that conversation is one joint activity among many, continuous with a surgeon and nurse passing instruments; the surgeon who holds out her hand without a word relies on the nurse's representing the same stage of the procedure, and no one has committed to anything. Conversation relies on the same capacity at every turn. Speakers choose referring expressions according to what they take the addressee to have in view (Clark & Murphy 1982), listeners signal uptake (Clark & Brennan 1991), and speakers

leave implicit what the hearer can supply. None of this requires public standing: a pronoun succeeds if we both have its referent in view, whether or not anything about it has been asserted.

But such cases make a poor diagnostic, because their contents usually also have, or soon acquire, public standing. We need a move that is felicitous only where mutual representation is present *and* public standing absent. Insinuation is such a move. Suppose that at a faculty meeting, after a contentious vote, I say:

(2) Well, some of us actually read the proposal before voting on it.

For (2) to succeed as an insinuation that my colleague Jim voted without reading, two conditions must hold. First, the content must be mutually recognized. Jim and the others must represent what I am getting at, and represent that I intend them to represent it; if no one gets it, I have made an odd remark about reading habits. Second, the content must not be publicly settled, either before or by the utterance. If Jim had already announced, to general laughter, that he hadn't read the thing, then (2) is no longer an insinuation. It is a reminder, or a jibe. And (2) does not itself settle the matter: if Jim demands, "Are you saying I didn't read it?", I can reply that I said no such thing, and the reply is not a lie in the way that denying an assertion would be (Pinker, Nowak & Lee 2008; Fricker 2012; Camp 2018). Insinuation lives exactly in the region where mutual representation holds and public standing does not.

That is why insinuation is diagnostic. On an account that locates presupposition and insinuation in a single state, the insinuated content either is in that state or it isn't. If it is, it should be available for presupposition, and it plainly isn't: "Since Jim didn't read the proposal, his vote shouldn't count" is exactly the move my insinuation was designed to avoid. If it isn't, the account has nothing to say about what makes (2) succeed. Geurts's commitment account faces the same fork from the other side: if common ground is shared commitment, the insinuated content is not common ground, and what coordinates its uptake is left unexplained. Camp (2018) sees this more clearly than anyone, and her distinction between record and common ground is the nearest ancestor of my view. Section 8 argues that her way of drawing it, as a nesting, cannot survive the cases that follow.

5. Repair, and its absence

The two mechanisms also fail differently, and the difference shows up in what can be done afterward.

Presupposition failure is normally repairable, and repairable retroactively. Lewis (1979) called the process accommodation: if no one objects, the presupposition "comes into existence," and the utterance counts as having been in order all along. Even where the hearer does object, the repair is straightforward. Ana, in Section 3, can say, "Fine. Let me put it

plainly: he's failing chemistry, and I know you saw it too." That is a public act, it confers public standing, and afterward (1) is available to be said again without complaint. A public move can create exactly what was missing.

Now suppose my insinuation in (2) misfires. Jim doesn't get it, or the room doesn't. What can I do? I can make the content explicit: "I mean that Jim didn't read the proposal." But that is not a repair of the insinuation. It is a different act, an accusation, which commits me and can be held against me. The hearer's options are no better. If Jim asks, "Are you implying I didn't read it?", he is not helping my insinuation succeed; he is forcing its content onto the record, which is the standard counter to insinuation and precisely what makes it one (Camp 2018). I could try another hint. But a second hint is a new attempt, not a retroactive fix. Nothing I or anyone else can do will make it the case that (2) succeeded. A missed insinuation admits no repair, since any public repair settles the content and thereby destroys the move.

This asymmetry is hard to explain if presupposition and insinuation draw on one store. Clark and Brennan's (1991) grounding model treats repair as the ordinary engine of common ground: participants collaborate, through clarification requests and reformulations, until they reach mutual understanding sufficient for current purposes. For explicit content that works well, because re-saying something is harmless. But insinuated content is exactly the content for which collaborative repair is self-defeating. Grounding is a process of mutual representation carried out by public acts, and when the content cannot survive becoming public, grounding has no move to make. Camp's view can explain the asymmetry as well, since on her view repair means going on record. The asymmetry tells against single-mechanism views, not against hers.

6. Transition

So far I have compared different contents. Now hold one fixed and watch it move. Return to the faculty meeting. I insinuate, with (2), that Jim didn't read the proposal, and the insinuation lands. Jim says, "Fine, I skimmed it," someone replies, "So you didn't read it," and Jim concedes. Later the chair remarks that votes cast without reading the proposal ought to be reconsidered, which, given the concession, entails that Jim's vote ought to be. Across these moves the content *Jim didn't read the proposal* changes what it licenses. At the start it can be insinuated but not presupposed. After Jim's concession it can be presupposed ("Since Jim didn't read it..."), and it can no longer be insinuated, since there is nothing left off the record to insinuate. After the chair's remark it is carried along by entailment into further commitments. What does not change, from the first move to the last, is that the participants mutually represent it. They had it in view when I insinuated it, and they have it in view now.

One content, one constant condition of mutual representation, and a licensing profile that shifts when, and only when, public standing does. If a single state were responsible for both

profiles, it is hard to see what in that state changed.

7. Independence without coincidence

The cases so far show that public standing and mutual representation license different moves. They do not yet show that there are two mechanisms rather than one with two outputs, or one derived from the other. The argument for that claim is abductive: I cannot prove that no deeper unifying state exists, but two independent mechanisms with common inputs explain the pattern better than the rivals do.

Start with independence. Neither mechanism is defined in terms of the other, and each can operate without the other. Mutual representation without public standing we have already seen. Public standing without mutual representation is familiar across time: commitment theorists have long insisted that commitments are deontic statuses, which outlast the beliefs and memories of those who hold them (Brandom 1994; Geurts 2019). What matters here is that the same dissociation occurs within a single conversation. At a department meeting the chair says, "So we're agreed: the deadline is the 15th." No one objects. Jim, as it happens, is answering email and does not take it in. An hour later the chair says, "Given the 15th deadline, the committee should meet next week." Her presupposition is in order. If Jim asks, "What deadline?", the fault is his, and what he owes is an excuse ("Sorry, I missed that"), not a correction. Excuses are owed only where there is a commitment to be excused from. Yet the content was never mutually represented. Jim never encoded it, so there is nothing for him to retrieve, and the dispositional reading of Section 2 does not help. Nor was it unavailable to him: it was said aloud in his presence, and so was mutually manifest in Sperber and Wilson's sense. He simply failed to take it up. Here the record outruns representation, and presupposition follows the record. The case is the mirror image of the report card. There, a content mutually represented but unsaid could be challenged; here, a content said but not mutually represented could not. Commitments are created by acts and persist through failures of uptake and memory; mutual representations exist only where uptake has occurred, and persist only while the participants can bring them to bear. Different conditions of creation and persistence are about as good a mark of distinct mechanisms as we are likely to get.

Why, then, do they so often coincide? Because they answer to the same inputs. The main input to public standing is public utterance: assertion, and its acceptance or non-rejection. But public utterance is, by its nature, manifest to those who witness it, and manifestness is the main input to mutual representation. When I assert something in your hearing, I commit myself and, in the same act, put the content before us both, in a way that each of us can see the other sees. Shared perceptual situations, histories, and communities (Clark & Marshall 1981) feed mutual representation directly and make public commitment cheap, which is why accommodating what is jointly evident is nearly frictionless. Two mechanisms fed by the same

causes will co-vary robustly without either being a mode of the other. The hypothesis also predicts where they should come apart: exactly where the inputs do. Manifestness without utterance should yield mutual representation without public standing, and utterance without uptake should yield public standing without mutual representation. The report card and the missed deadline are those two cases.

An analogy may help. In Britain, which side of the road to drive on is fixed in two ways: by law, a normative status conferred by legislative acts, and by convention in Lewis's (1969) sense, a system of mutual expectation among drivers. The two coincide almost everywhere. But on a private estate road the law may be silent while the convention governs, and a new rule binds before anyone has adjusted their expectations. No one concludes that "the rule of the road" names a single thing. Legal obligation and conventional expectation are distinct, they converge because both respond to the same public events, and for most purposes we can ignore the difference. I am claiming that common ground is like this.

This is also why the convergence is *accidental* in the older sense of the word: not chance, but not in the nature of either mechanism. The rival hypotheses each fail somewhere specific. If public standing were derivative of mutual representation, the publicity differential and the missed deadline would be inexplicable. If mutual representation were derivative of public standing, insinuation and its irreparability would be. And if there were a single state with two outputs, the transition of Section 6, in which one output changes while the other's basis stays fixed, would be. Two independent mechanisms with common inputs predict all of this, together with the robust co-occurrence that made unification look compulsory. The argument's weak point is the usual one: a cleverer unifier might do better. The next section asks what it would have to pay.

8. The cost of unification

Suppose someone insists that there must be a single common ground after all. My claim is that any single-mechanism account faces a dilemma. Either it leaves one of the differentials of Sections 3 through 6 unexplained, or it explains it by adding structure that turns out, on inspection, to be the other mechanism under a different description.

Consider first the doxastic unifiers: Stalnaker, Yalcin, and Clark and Brennan all build common ground out of the participants' attitudes. Taken strictly, they leave the publicity differential unexplained, and the available fix, as Section 3 showed, makes acceptance the participants' registration of the first mechanism. Yalcin's definition already has the right number of parts: an attitude of acceptance and a layer of common knowledge on top. My disagreement is that he welds them into a single condition, when the acceptance part answers to public acts, the common-knowledge part answers to manifestness, and each can be present without the other.

Consider next the commitment unifier. On Geurts's (2019) view, common ground is shared

commitment, and he is, I think, right about presupposition. But the view leaves insinuation, audience design, and uptake unexplained, since none of these involve commitment. The natural fix is to posit weaker commitments: perhaps the insinuator is committed to having *meant* something. But insinuated content is precisely content the speaker may deny without lying, and a commitment that can be disavowed without violation does not do the normative work that makes commitment explanatory. What makes the insinuation succeed is that the participants represent the content and represent each other as representing it.

A different unifier grants that context is plural. Lewis's (1979) conversational score has many components: Thomason (1990) adds joint plans, Roberts (2012) questions under discussion, and Farkas and Bruce (2010) individual discourse commitments and a "Table" of issues raised but unresolved. Why isn't my second mechanism one of these? Because they are updated by conversational moves and kept as a single public ledger. A question is under discussion because someone raised it; an issue is on the Table because someone put it there. Such components are publicly in view without being settled, and so belong to the first mechanism. Insinuated content has no place on the ledger: Jim's "Are you saying I didn't read it?" would put it there, and would end the insinuation. Lewis's salience and Thomason's plan recognition are the instructive exceptions, since they respond to manifestness rather than to moves. The tradition already houses components of both kinds; my claim is that they belong to two systems with different kinematics, not to one score.

That leaves the views that already contain two structures. As I read Camp (2018), the conversational record is the part of the common ground that speakers are officially on the hook for. Insinuation can update the common ground without touching the record, and the most deniable insinuations, such as a bribe hinted to a police officer, may yield mutual belief without reaching common ground at all (cf. Geurts 2024, §3.2). This handles insinuation well, and it explains the repair asymmetry too. But nesting the record within common ground predicts that nothing is on the record that is not also in the common ground. The missed deadline of Section 7 falsifies that prediction. The deadline is on the conversational record, since Jim can be held to it within the very conversation in which it was set. But it is in no common ground built from the participants' attitudes, since Jim has no attitude toward it.

Simons (2025) and Bary (2025) have already un-nested the structures, and nothing here tells against their central claims. Simons shows that interpretation draws on what is available to the hearer, which can outrun the common ground. Bary splits the common ground into common beliefs and commitments and shows that each can exist without the other: the goat yields common belief without commitment, and a lie yields commitment without belief. My disagreements are narrower, but they are substantive. First, belief is the wrong relatum. A lie is still mutually represented; what it lacks is the speaker's belief. The missed deadline separates commitment from mutual representation itself, which is the stronger dissociation and the one a theory of conversational context needs, since insinuated suspicions and fictions

are represented without being believed. Second, Bary assigns the formulation of utterances to common belief. The report card is a case of complete common belief in which a presupposition remains open to refusal, so informative presupposition belongs with commitment. Third, neither view offers a general account of why the two structures normally coincide, or a prediction of where they should come apart. Section 7's common-inputs hypothesis supplies both.

The general lesson is that a unified account can always be made to fit the data, but only by adding a component sensitive to exactly what the other mechanism is sensitive to. At that point the unification is nominal, and parsimony, its main advantage, counts against it.

9. Convergence without unity

We can now state the thesis in full. Common ground is the accidental convergence of at least two independently operating mechanisms. The first tracks mutual public commitment; it is created by public acts, persists through changes in the participants' minds, and licenses what may be presupposed without challenge. The second tracks mutual representation; it is fed by manifestness, persists only as long as the participants can bring the content to bear, and coordinates joint activity, including what may be insinuated. The two converge because they answer to the same inputs, above all public utterance, which both commits and makes manifest. They diverge where those inputs come apart: where something is mutually known but unsaid (Section 3), conveyed but unowned (Section 4), or said but not taken up (Section 7); where a failure can or cannot be repaired by going public (Section 5); and where a single content changes its public status while its representational status holds still (Section 6).

This does not threaten the formal models that descend from Stalnaker. A single context set is an excellent idealization wherever the two mechanisms converge, which is most of the time. What it threatens is the foundational project, pursued by Yalcin (2024) from one side and Geurts (2019) from the other, of saying what common ground *is*, as if the answer were one configuration of states or one set of statuses. On the present view that question has no single answer. "Common ground" is better understood as a projection of correlated variables, a convenient summary of two quantities that usually move together, than as a thing with a nature of its own. The better foundational questions are what each mechanism is, what feeds it, and why they so reliably agree.

Is the disagreement, then, merely verbal? Geurts (2024) already calls mentalist and normative accounts complementary, and Camp, Simons, and Bary already divide the common ground. Perhaps all that remains is who gets the words. I do not think so. A dispute is verbal when the parties agree about the facts, and here they do not. If the mentalist and normative descriptions were two perspectives on one thing, as complementarity suggests, they should not dissociate in their conditions of creation, persistence, and repair; Sections 3, 5, and 7 argue

that they do. If commitment did the explanatory work in insinuation, denying an insinuation should violate a commitment; Section 8 argues that it does not. And if the record nested within common ground, there should be no commitments outside it; the deadline Jim missed is one. A theorist who accepts all this and still reserves "common ground" for one system makes a verbal choice, but on top of the substantive view defended here.

There is also a payoff for an older dispute, over whether conversation is fundamentally an exchange of mental states or a jointly governed normative practice. If I am right, it is both, through different mechanisms. Camp's insinuator and the parent who says "we haven't talked about that yet" are each exploiting the joint between them.

10. Conclusion

I have argued that the common ground of a conversation is two things that usually travel together. To be sure, the argument has limits. The case for independence is abductive, and I have said "at least two" mechanisms advisedly, since mutual representation may itself fragment further. The view also makes predictions that armchair cases can only suggest. If presupposition answers to public standing and insinuation to mutual representation, then it should be possible to manipulate the two independently in experimental vignettes, crossing whether a content is mutually known with whether it has been said, and to find that judgments of whether a hearer could reasonably object that the matter is not yet settled track only the second factor, while judgments of insinuation success require the first and are undermined by the second. The report card and the missed deadline fill two cells of such a design. I would like to see the whole of it run.

But the cases in hand are already telling. Ben, who says "we haven't talked about that yet," knows exactly what Ana knows. Jim, who hears "some of us read the proposal," has not been told anything he can be held to. Neither fits comfortably in a theory on which there is one common ground. Both fit easily if there are two mechanisms, converging on most roads, diverging at the edges. That does not refute unification. It should, I think, be a nudge away from it.

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